

THE BELL CURVE, THAT GREAT INTELLECTUAL FRAUD*

Not worth a pastis—Quételet's error—The average man is a monster—Let's deify it—Yes or no—Not so literary an experiment

Forget everything you heard in college statistics or probability theory. If you never took such a class, even better. Let us start from the very beginning.

THE GAUSSIAN AND THE MANDELBROTIAN

I was transiting through the Frankfurt airport in December 2001, on my way from Oslo to Zurich.

I had time to kill at the airport and it was a great opportunity for me to buy dark European chocolate, especially since I have managed to successfully convince myself that airport calories don't count. The cashier handed me, among other things, a ten deutschmark bill, an (illegal) scan of which can be seen on the next page. The deutschmark banknotes were going to be put out of circulation in a matter of days, since Europe was switching to the euro. I kept it as a valedictory. Before the arrival of the euro, Europe had plenty of national currencies, which was good for printers, money changers, and of course currency traders like this (more or less) humble author. As I was eating my dark European chocolate and wistfully looking at the bill, I almost choked. I suddenly noticed, for the first time, that there was something curious about it. The bill bore the portrait of Carl Friedrich Gauss and a picture of his Gaussian bell curve.



The last ten deutschmark bill, representing Gauss and, to his right, the bell curve of Mediocristan.